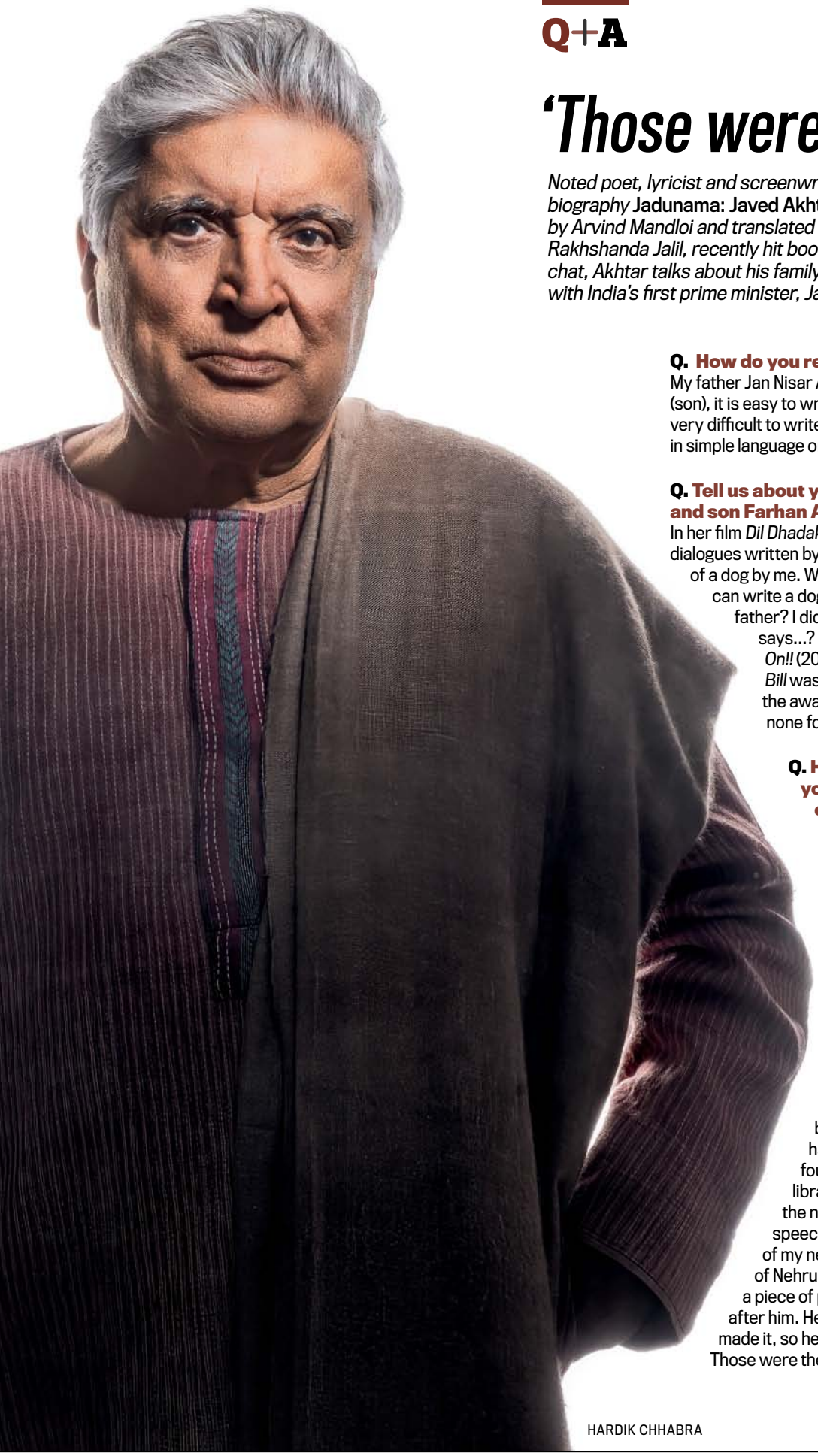
Q+A

‘Those were the days’

Noted poet, lyricist and screenwriter ***Javed Akhtar’s*** *biography* **Jadunama: Javed Akhtar’s Journey,** *written by Arvind Mandloi and translated into English by Rakhshanda Jalil, recently hit bookstores. In a candid chat, Akhtar talks about his family and an early encounter with India’s first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru*



HARDIK CHHABRA

Q. How do you remember your father?

My father Jan Nisar Akhtar once said to me that *beta* (son), it is easy to write in difficult language, but it is very difficult to write in easy language. You can write in simple language only when your thoughts are clear.

Q. Tell us about your daughter Zoya Akhtar and son Farhan Akhtar.

In her film *Dil Dhadakne Do* (2015), Zoya got all the dialogues written by someone else but the dialogues of a dog by me. Why would she think that no one can write a dog’s dialogues better than her father? I didn’t ask out of fear, what if she says...? Similarly, for Farhan’s film *Rock On!!* (2008), the song *Meri Laundry Ka Ik Bill* was written by me. That year, I got all the awards for *Jodhaa Akbar* (2008), but none for *Rock On*.

Q. How would you describe your wife Shabana Azmi and ex-wife Honey Irani?

Shabana is a perfectionist in every role, be it of a daughter or a friend...She is a friend on whom I can depend. Honey and I are best friends. She once said something that I have mentioned in the book, that people who are good friends should never get married.

Q. How did you meet Jawaharlal Nehru?

You can’t imagine modern India without Nehruji... I still remember how I got his autograph. He had come to Aligarh to lay the foundation stone for a university library. My friends and I were to sing the national anthem there. He gave a speech and proceeded to his car. One of my neighbours had given me a picture of Nehru and a tricolour drawn on a piece of paper. I gave it to Nehruji, running after him. He must have thought that I had made it, so he took out his pen and signed it. Those were the days, and then there’s today.

with Saurabh Dwivedi